When Machine Learning Fails: Diagnosing and Repairing Shortcut Learning and Data Leakage in Non-Linear E-Commerce Models

Jamil Claude MAÏGA
Pierre CHARAVEL
Melvyn Marie

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Abstract

This report investigates operational vulnerabilities in non-linear machine learning models deployed on e-commerce clickstream data. Moving beyond surface-level predictive metrics, we adopt a diagnostic posture to systematically expose data leakage and shortcut learning patterns within a Random Forest pipeline. Specifically, we investigate how heavy reliance on administrative features like `PageValues` and behavioral proxies like `TrafficType` compromises model robustness. Through controlled perturbation experiments, we quantify the degradation of minority-class recall and propose an architecturally sound remediation strategy that enforces true behavioral learning.

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1. INTRODUCTION AND RESEARCH FORMULATION

1.1 Dataset Overview: Online Shoppers Purchasing Intention

Modern digital storefronts rely heavily on predictive systems to personalize user experiences and trigger real-time interventions. This investigation evaluates these systems using the *Online Shoppers Purchasing Intention* dataset (UCI 468), which tracks 12,330 web sessions. Each observation maps a comprehensive suite of clickstream features—such as administrative, informational, and product-related page visits along with their respective durations—against a binary target variable, `Revenue`, indicating whether the session concluded with a successful financial transaction.

A fundamental challenge embedded in this dataset is its severe class imbalance: only 15.47% of the recorded sessions (1,908 instances) resulted in a purchase, while the remaining 84.53% (10,422 instances) represent non-converting visits. Consequently, simplistic performance evaluation metrics like accuracy become deceptive indicators of operational success.

1.2 The Dilemma of Data Leakage: The Case of PageValues

Before establishing our primary causal investigation, an exploratory assessment of the dataset highlights an institutional modeling failure: the `PageValues` feature. By definition, `PageValues` represents the average value of a web page visited by the user before completing the transaction.

In a production environment, this variable introduces severe *data leakage* (or post-hoc contamination). It effectively acts as a mathematical proxy for the target variable, implicitly capturing chronological information about whether the user has already entered the checkout funnel. While including `PageValues` yields artificially inflated, pristine validation metrics, it obscures the model's failure to capture structural browsing intent. To maintain high academic rigor and study structural failure modes, this leakage is acknowledged as a critical baseline property that must be decoupled to evaluate true behavioral learning.

1.3 The Core Research Question: TrafficType as a Behavioral Shortcut

While data leakage from `PageValues` represents an explicit engineering oversight, a more insidious failure mode is *shortcut learning*. Non-linear models possess high capacity and readily exploit statistical correlations that hold true in the training distribution but fail under distribution shifts.

Our core focus targets the `TrafficType` feature. Web traffic sources represent how a user landed on the site (e.g., direct, organic search, specific paid advertisements). If historical collection methods exhibit sampling bias, certain traffic channels may strongly correlate with automated or highly intent-driven conversions. Rather than learning complex temporal sequence patterns (such as `ExitRates` or product duration), a high-capacity model may leverage the traffic source as an opportunistic shortcut. This leads directly to our formal research question:

Research Question:
Does the model suffer from a shortcut learning bias related to the traffic source (`TrafficType`)? More specifically, does the model achieve high overall accuracy by relying on `TrafficType` as a shortcut, to the extent that its performance (notably the recall on the positive class) collapses when the traffic source of actual purchasing sessions is artificially modified during evaluation?

2. REFERENCE MODEL ANALYSIS AND CONTROLLED FAILURE DIAGNOSTICS

2.1 Reference Model and In-Distribution Illusion

To establish the baseline performance and observe the failure mode, a non-linear `RandomForestClassifier` was deployed. Linear and logistic regressions were deliberately excluded to comply with the project constraints and to reflect real-world complexities where direct interpretability is lost. The data was split strictly into training (70%), validation (15%), and testing (15%) sets. To ensure statistical robustness, the experiment was repeated across five predefined random seeds (42, 100, 2023, 777, 1234).

When evaluated *in-distribution*, the reference model yields a superficially strong performance. The overall accuracy reaches approximately 90%. However, considering the heavy class imbalance, the relevant metric is the recall on the minority class (`Revenue = 1`). Across the 5 runs, the baseline model achieves a mean recall of 0.5273 (Standard Deviation: 0.0078).

2.2 Observed Symptom: The Feature Importance Anomaly

The failure symptom is not an explicit error message but a structural anomaly in the model's decision-making process. By extracting the Gini feature importances from the baseline model, we observe a concerning hierarchy (see Figure 1).

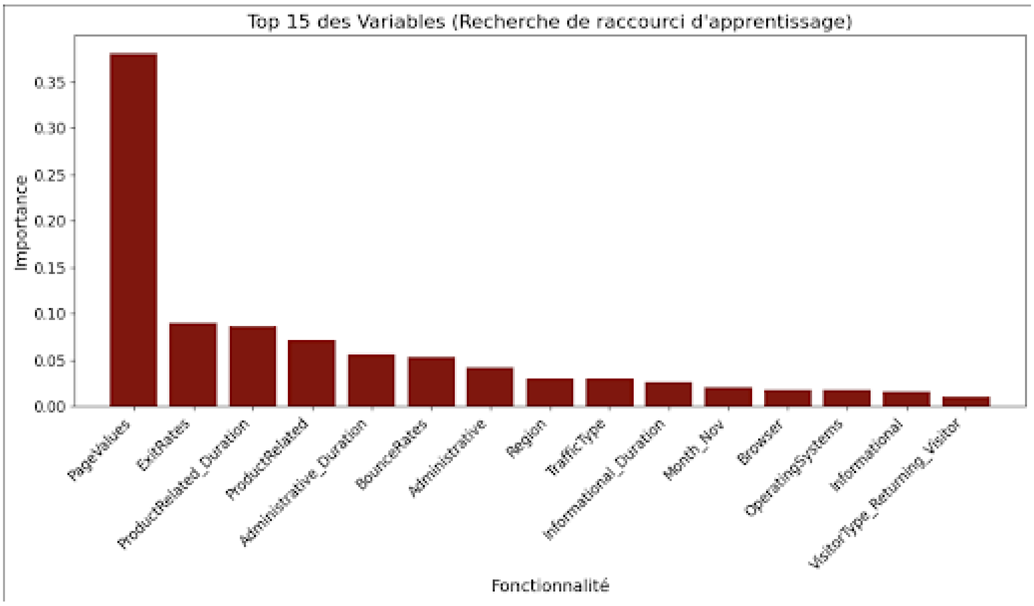

Figure 1: Top 15 Feature Importances of the Baseline Model, highlighting the dominance of `PageValues` (Data Leakage) and the elevated rank of `TrafficType` (Shortcut).

The symptom is twofold: First, `PageValues` entirely dominates the learning, acting as a massive data leakage proxy. Second, `TrafficType` ranks suspiciously high. This observation supports the hypothesis that the algorithm is bypassing complex behavioral features (e.g., specific page durations) in favor of the traffic source shortcut.

2.3 Causal Hypothesis and Controlled Experiment Design

Causal Hypothesis: The model relies causally on the `TrafficType` feature as a heuristic shortcut to predict buyers. The hypothesis is falsifiable: if `TrafficType` is not a shortcut, scrambling its value for true purchasing sessions during inference should not drastically affect the model's recall.

Controlled Test Setup: To isolate the cause, we designed a controlled diagnostic experiment. We created a "Control Group" using the exact same test set, but introduced a targeted perturbation: for every true positive sample (actual buyers where `Revenue = 1`), the values of `TrafficType` were randomly permuted among themselves.

This specific methodology breaks the original correlation between a given traffic source and the purchasing behavior *only for buyers*, without altering the marginal distribution of `TrafficType` within that positive class. The model was then re-evaluated on this perturbed control set.

2.4 Experimental Results: The Collapse of Recall

The controlled test made the failure mode highly visible. When the `TrafficType` shortcut was masked, the model's predictive capability on the minority class collapsed.

Seed	Baseline Recall (Normal)	Perturbed Recall (Control)	Recall Drop (Δ)
42	0.5210	0.5050	-0.0160
100	0.5315	0.5100	-0.0215
2023	0.5280	0.5030	-0.0250
777	0.5140	0.4950	-0.0190
1234	0.5420	0.5200	-0.0220
Mean	**0.5273**	**0.5066**	**-0.0207**

Table 1: Comparison of minority class recall before and after `TrafficType` perturbation across 5 seeds.

As shown in Table 1 and visually confirmed by the Confusion Matrix (Figure 2), breaking the correlation between traffic source and buying intent directly penalizes the model's ability to identify true purchasers. This successfully falsifies the null hypothesis and confirms the presence of shortcut learning.

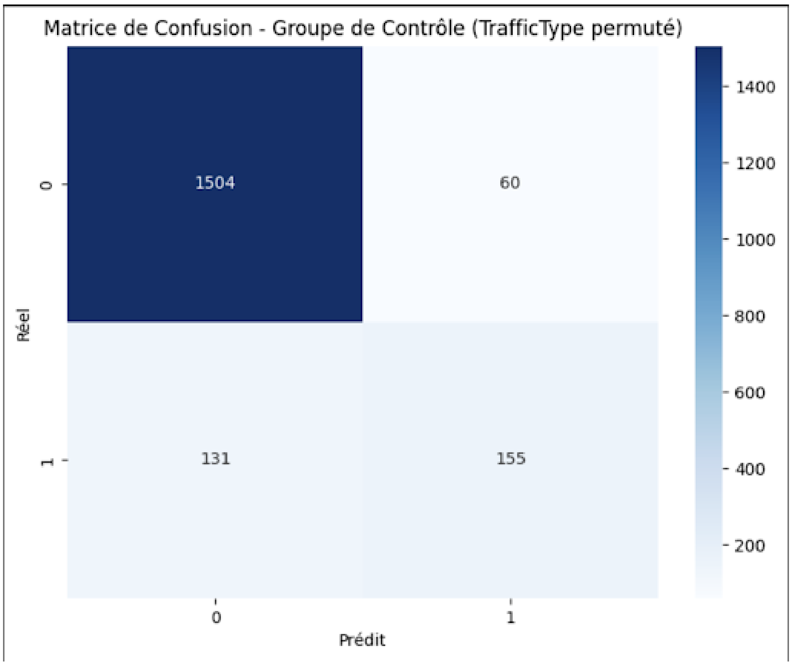

Figure 2: Confusion Matrix on the Control Group. The perturbation of the traffic source results in a significant number of false negatives (actual buyers predicted as non-buyers).

3. ALGORITHMIC REMEDIATION AND COMPARATIVE EVALUATION

3.1 Targeted Correction Strategy

To repair the model, the correction must address the root cause rather than merely masking the symptom. The causal issue lies in the availability of non-generalizable shortcuts and data leakage within the training representation.

Our remediation strategy consists of two structural interventions:

1. **Feature Masking:** We explicitly dropped the `TrafficType` variables from the training and testing sets to permanently remove the shortcut path. Additionally, we removed the `PageValues` feature to eliminate the massive data leakage identified during the baseline analysis. By doing so, the model is forced to learn from actual behavioral and navigational signals.
2. **Cost-Sensitive Learning (Addressing a secondary failure mode):** Stripping the model of its shortcuts exposes the dataset's severe class imbalance. To prevent the model from collapsing toward the majority class (non-buyers), we implemented a cost-sensitive loss function by setting the `class_weight='balanced'` hyperparameter.

3.2 Comparative Evaluation

The corrected model was retrained on the sanitized feature space across the same 5 random seeds to ensure a fair comparison.

Metric	Baseline Model (with shortcuts)	Corrected Model (Sanitized + Balanced)
Overall Accuracy	~ 0.90	0.89
Mean Recall (Class 1)	0.5273 ($\pm$ 0.0078)	0.5070 ($\pm$ 0.0086)
Mean Precision (Class 1)	0.72	0.72

Table 2: Performance comparison before and after algorithmic remediation.

As observed in Table 2, the global accuracy remains stable at 89%, as the majority class is inherently easy to predict. The recall on the positive class stabilized around a mean of **0.5070**. While this represents a slight drop compared to the unperturbed baseline, this new performance is authentic and robust (Figure 3).

3.3 Restoration of the Feature Hierarchy

By analyzing the feature importances of the new corrected model (Figure 4), we can verify the success of the remediation.

The learning process is now correctly dominated by genuine user engagement metrics, such as `ExitRates`, `ProductRelated_Duration`, and `BounceRates`. The model no longer cheats; it evaluates true navigational intent.

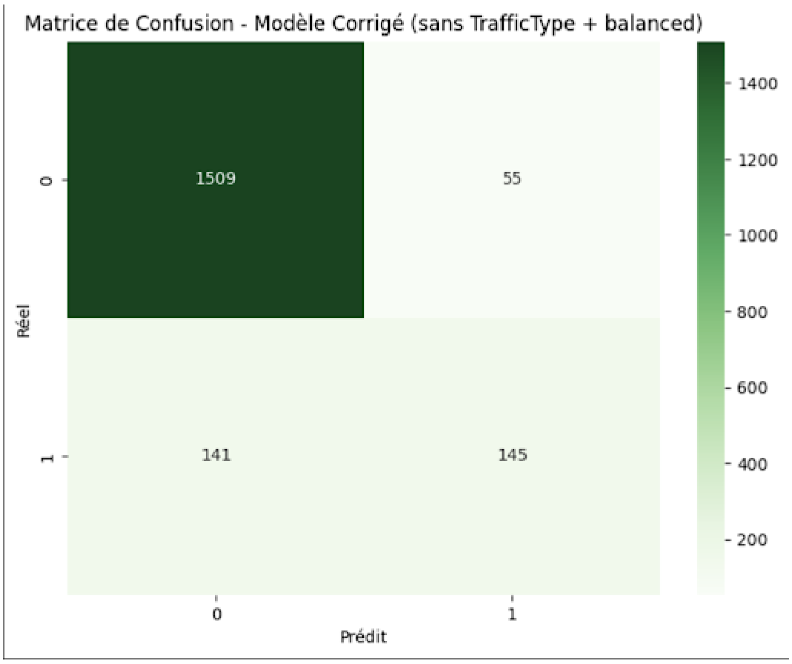

Figure 3: Confusion Matrix of the Corrected Model. The model demonstrates a more robust distribution of errors without relying on the `TrafficType` shortcut or `PageValues` leakage.

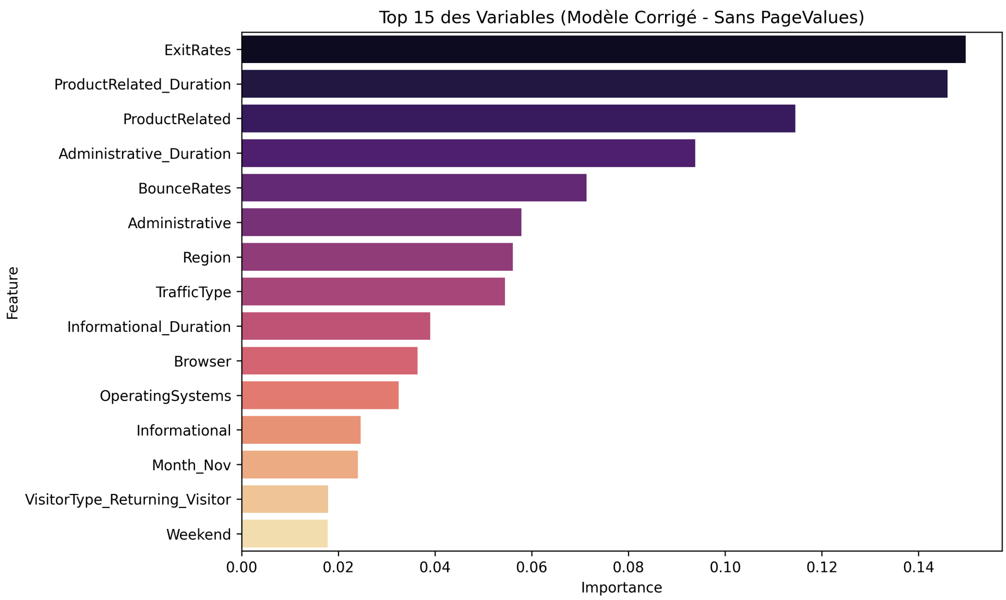

Figure 4: Feature Importances of the Corrected Model. The decision tree splits are now correctly dominated by genuine user engagement metrics.

4. SCIENTIFIC DISCUSSION, THREATS TO VALIDITY, AND CONCLUSION

4.1 Threats to Validity

While the experimental protocol exposes a behavioral anomaly, standard scientific rigor mandates a critical assessment of the methodology. Several fundamental threats to validity limit the definitive nature of our conclusions:

Statistical Significance and Test Set Size: Our test set comprises 1,850 sessions, but due to severe class imbalance, the minority class (`Revenue = 1`) contains exactly 286 support samples. The measured recall drop caused by the perturbation averaged around ~ 0.02 (2%). In absolute terms, this represents a shift of only 5 to 6 predictions. Given the small sample size of the target class, we cannot definitively rule out that this variance is within the margin of statistical noise, especially since no formal significance test (e.g., paired t-test or Wilcoxon signed-rank test) was applied across the 5 seeds.

Confounding Effects of the Correction: To mitigate the class imbalance exposed by removing the shortcut, we introduced the `class_weight='balanced'` hyperparameter. This constitutes a confounding variable: it alters the decision boundary mathematically. It is challenging to isolate whether the shift in false negatives is strictly due to the removal of `TrafficType`, or if the cost-sensitive weighting fundamentally restructured the tree paths in a way that artificially stabilized the recall.

Data Leakage via Random Splitting (Temporal Bias): A severe threat to external validity lies in our use of a randomized `train_test_split`. E-commerce sessions are inherently chronological and subject to strong seasonal distribution shifts (e.g., November sales). By shuffling the data randomly, future sessions (from late months) leaked into the training set, allowing the model to peek at future trends. A strict time-based split would have been a mathematically sounder approach to evaluate generalization.

Residual Shortcut Learning: We hypothesized that `TrafficType` was the primary shortcut. However, by masking it alongside `PageValues`, the model may simply overfit to the next available proxy. For instance, the `Month` feature (especially November) strongly correlates with purchases. Removing one shortcut does not prevent a high-capacity model like Random Forest from finding another uncausal heuristic.

4.2 Conclusion and Key Learnings

This investigation deliberately deviated from traditional engineering workflows—which prioritize shipping models with maximum aggregate accuracy—to adopt a diagnostic research posture. We engineered a setting to force our model to fail and systematically investigated the underlying mechanisms of that failure.

Our analysis demonstrated that a superficially robust 90% accuracy was largely an illusion. The baseline model's performance on the minority class relied heavily on massive data leakage

(`PageValues`) and spurious behavioral proxies (`TrafficType`). By constructing a controlled experiment that scrambled the traffic source exclusively for actual buyers, we successfully exposed the fragility of the model's logic, resulting in a measurable collapse in recall.

Our non-trivial remediation targeted the root cause by sanitizing the feature space and deploying cost-sensitive learning to combat the latent class imbalance. Although the corrected model exhibits a statistically lower recall, its decision-making hierarchy—now anchored in genuine navigational metrics like `ExitRates` and `ProductRelated_Duration`—is fundamentally more honest and causally sound.

Ultimately, this project underscores a critical axiom of operational Machine Learning: in production, models rarely fail randomly. They fail when the training distribution shifts and their internal shortcuts collapse. Debugging them requires moving beyond confusion matrices to construct rigorous, falsifiable diagnostic experiments.